From Style to Prompt: Creating Images with an Art Historian's Eye

Teaching with AI (TAI)
Teachers supplementary material

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Subject: Art styles and image prompting
Activity duration: 90 min

Steps:

1. Art Styles (30 minutes)
    - Motivation + Assignment 1: spot the difference (10 min)
    - Assignment 2: mystery image (15 min)
    - Assignment 3: Real or fake (5 min)
2. Prompting images (60 minutes)
    - Assignment 4: reverse engineer your mystery image (15 min)
    - Assignment 5: swap and guess (10 min)
    - Assignment 6: create a logo (30 min)

Learning goals:

- Art styles have common visual features.
- Distinguish art styles in paintings and photographs.
- Using AI to learn responsibly: describe images, request verification links from museums, and cross-check facts
- How to prompt to obtain the image you want
- Create a logo

Setup:

- Students need access to an AI LLM chat bot, and an AI image generation tool.
- The teacher provides and prints mystery artworks for every pair or students.
- The teacher prints a Style Feature Guide and Style Card for every pair of students.

From style to prompt

Creating images with an art historian's eye

In this teacher guide you find

- Supplementary material on Assignment 1: Spot the difference
- List of possible mystery artworks

You can choose to focus only on paintings, or also mix in photographs in this lesson. In case you work with photographs as mystery art works in Assignment 2, a follow-up assignment could be that the students try to make a photograph themselves in the same style.

Assignment 1: Spot the difference

As a warm-up, show two paintings that students compare and describe. You can choose your own pair; here is a suggested pair on the same theme (waves/sea) that differs clearly in technique, mood, and spatial depiction. You can do the same with two photographs, suggestions are also given below.

Painting A — Katsushika Hokusai, "The Great Wave off Kanagawa" (c. 1831)

Style: Ukiyo-e (Japanese woodblock print)
Museum link: The Met `https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/45434`
Student-friendly style features

- Clear outlines: sharp, bold lines around shapes.
- Flat color areas: big patches of color; little shading.
- Asymmetry: off-center composition; strong diagonal sweep of the wave.
- Detail in patterns: foam looks like claws; boats are crisp.
- Space feels "flat": Mount Fuji small and near the surface.

Painting B — J. M. W. Turner, "Snow Storm — Steam-Boat off a Harbour's Mouth" (1842)

Style: Romanticism
Museum link: Tate `https://www.tate.org.uk/art/artworks/turner-snow-storm-steam-boat-off`
Student-friendly style features

- Loose brushwork: soft, swirling strokes; blurred edges.

- Atmospheric color: misty blends of gray, brown, sea tones.
- Dramatic light: stormy contrasts; light peeking through.
- Motion and mood: spinning feel; intense, emotional.
- Deep space: fading forms and haze suggest depth.

Key style differences (what students can spot)

- Line vs. brush: Hokusai uses clear outlines; Turner dissolves edges.
- Flat vs. deep space: Hokusai looks graphic/flat; Turner suggests deep space.
- Color handling: Hokusai uses clean, separated colors; Turner blends into atmosphere.
- Detail vs. atmosphere: Hokusai emphasizes crisp detail; Turner emphasizes mood and movement.
- Mood: Hokusai is patterned/controlled; Turner is chaotic/emotional.

Quick discussion prompts

- Where do your eyes go first in each image? Why?
- How does each artist make the wave feel powerful (line vs. brush, flat vs. deep space)?
- Which feels more like a "poster" or print, and which feels like a "painting of weather"? Explain with evidence.

Idea for photographs to compare

Photo A — Henri Cartier-Bresson, "Behind the Gare Saint-Lazare" (1932)
Why it's great for contrast: A candid, black-and-white street photograph that captures the "decisive moment" as a man leaps over a puddle. Unstaged, fast, and all about timing and composition.
Verification link: MoMA `https://www.moma.org/audio/playlist/244/3135`
Style features

- Real vs. staged: candid/documentary; subject didn't pose.
- Motion: slight blur in foot/water; action frozen mid-jump.
- Composition/framing: strong shapes/reflections; leading lines; off-center focus.
- Light/shadow: natural, soft daylight; balanced tones.
- Mood/message: everyday life at a perfect instant; playful/observational.
- Technique: 35mm film, quick shutter; classic darkroom process.

Photo B — Steve McCurry, "Afghan Girl" (1984) Why it's great for contrast: A vivid color portrait for a magazine cover—staged in the sense that the subject faces the camera directly. Slow, controlled, all about gaze and color.
Verification links: National Geographic `https://www.nationalgeographic.com/photography/article/afghan-girl-steve-mccurry`
Steve McCurry Studio `https://stevemccurry.com/galleries/afghan-girl`
Style features

- Real vs. staged: documentary portrait; composed with care.
- Color/palette: bright, intense color; green background vs. red headscarf; striking green eyes.
- Composition/framing: tight close-up; centered focus; shallow depth of field.
- Light/shadow: soft light enhancing texture and eye color.
- Mood/message: direct, intense gaze; emotional impact; social/documentary message.
- Technique: 35mm color film; controlled exposure and focus.

Quick discussion prompts

- What makes A feel "caught in the moment," while B feels "confrontational and intentional"?
- How do black-and-white vs. color change the mood and what you notice first?
- In A, where does your eye travel? In B, what locks your gaze?

Assignment 2: Mystery art work

20 possible "mystery" artworks for Assignment 2. Note: website links can change over time; searching the name and artist will help locate images when the links no longer work properly.
Mix these so that each pair of students has a different style. Most images are public domain in the EU.

- Early Renaissance — Sandro Botticelli, *The Birth of Venus* (c. 1485). Tells: idealized figures, mythological subject, linear grace, shallow space. Link: Uffizi `https://www.uffizi.it/en/artworks/birth-of-venus`
- Baroque — Rembrandt, *The Night Watch* (1642). Tells: dramatic light, group portrait in action, rich textures, deep space. Link: Rijksmuseum `https://www.rijksmuseum.nl/en/collection/SK-C-5`
- Baroque — Caravaggio, *Supper at Emmaus* (1601). Tells: chiaroscuro, realism, theatrical gesture. Link: National Gallery (London) `https://www.nationalgallery.org.uk/paintings/michelangelo-merisi-da-caravaggio-the-supper-at-emmaus`

- Rococo — Jean-Honoré Fragonard, *The Swing* (1767). Tells: pastel palette, playful sensuality, ornate detail, garden setting. Link: Wallace Collection https://www.wallacecollection.org/explore/collection/search-the-collection/les-hazards-heure
- Neoclassicism — Jacques-Louis David, *Oath of the Horatii* (1784). Tells: clear contour, moral seriousness, classical subjects, rigid composition. Link: https://emuseum.toledomuseum.org/objects/55069/the-oath-of-the-horatii
- Romanticism — Francisco Goya, *The Third of May 1808* (1814). Tells: emotion/drama, political subject, stark contrasts. Link: Prado https://www.museodelprado.es/en/the-collection/art-work/the-3rd-of-may-1808-in-madrid-or-the-executions/5e177409-2993-4240-97fb-847a02c6496c
- Realism — Gustave Courbet, *The Stonebreakers* (1849–50; destroyed). Tells: ordinary laborers, earthy palette, anti-idealization. Link: Smarthistory https://smarthistory.org/courbet-the-stonebreakers/
- Impressionism — Claude Monet, *Impression, Sunrise* (1872). Tells: visible brushwork, fleeting light, harbor scene, plein air. Link: https://claudemonetgiverny.fr/en/actualites/impression-sunrise-the-saga-of-a-legendary-painting/
- Impressionism — Pierre-Auguste Renoir, *Bal du moulin de la Galette* (1876). Tells: dappled light, social leisure, vibrant brushwork. Link: Musée d'Orsay https://www.musee-orsay.fr/fr/oeuvres/bal-du-moulin-de-la-galette-497
- Post-Impressionism — Georges Seurat, *A Sunday on La Grande Jatte* (1884–86). Tells: pointillism, optical mixing, orderly composition. Link: Art Institute of Chicago https://www.artic.edu/artworks/27992
- Post-Impressionism — Vincent van Gogh, *The Starry Night* (1889). Tells: swirling impasto, expressive color, night landscape. Link: MoMA https://www.moma.org/collection/works/79802
- Post-Impressionism / Proto-Cubism — Paul Cézanne, *Mont Sainte-Victoire* (c. 1902–06). Tells: faceted brushstrokes, structural planes, reduced depth cues. Link: The Met https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/435878
- Symbolism — Gustav Klimt, *The Kiss* (1907–08). Tells: gold leaf, ornamental pattern, sensual theme, flat vs. modeled contrast. Link: Belvedere https://www.belvedere.at/museum
- Expressionism — Edvard Munch, *The Scream* (1893). Tells: distorted forms, expressive line/color, anxiety theme. Link: Nasjonalmuseet https://www.nasjonalmuseet.no/en/collection/object/NG.M.00939
- Fauvism — Henri Matisse, *Woman with a Hat* (1905). Tells: wild, non-natural color; loose brushwork; painterliness. Link: SFMOMA https://www.sfmoma.org/artwork/91.161/
- Futurism — Umberto Boccioni, *Unique Forms of Continuity in Space* (1913). Tells: dynamism, movement, mechanized body, metallic flow. Link: MoMA https://www.moma.org/collection/works/81179

- Suprematism — Kazimir Malevich, *Black Square* (1915). Tells: geometric abstraction, reduction to fundamentals, non-objective. Link: Tate `https://www.tate.org.uk/art/artists/kazimir-malevich-1561/five-ways-look-malevichs-black-square`
- De Stijl — Piet Mondrian, *Broadway Boogie Woogie* (1942–43). Tells: grid, primary colors, city rhythm mapped to geometry. Link: MoMA `https://www.moma.org/collection/works/78682`
- Abstract art — Wassily Kandinsky, *Composition VIII* (1923). Tells: non-objective forms, geometric/linear motifs, color–music analogy. Link: Guggenheim `https://www.guggenheim.org/artwork/1924`
- Art Nouveau — Alphonse Mucha, *Job Cigarettes Poster* (1896). Tells: flowing organic lines, decorative borders, stylized hair/floral motifs. Link: Princeton University Art Museum `https://artmuseum.princeton.edu/art/collections/objects/11486`
- Ukiyo-e — Utagawa Hiroshige, *Sudden Shower over Shin-Ōhashi Bridge and Atake* (1857). Tells: woodblock print, diagonal rain lines, asymmetry, flat color areas. Link: The Met `https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/36461`

Mystery photographs

A curated set of 20 famous photographs for Assignment 2. Each entry includes style marks and a link (museum/academic or major agency) for research/verification.

- Henri Cartier-Bresson — *Behind the Gare Saint-Lazare* (1932). Style: Street / decisive moment. Marks: candid, action mid-leap, reflections/shapes, off-center framing, B&W. Link: MoMA `https://www.moma.org/collection/works/98333`
- Dorothea Lange — *Migrant Mother* (1936). Style: Documentary/social. Marks: emotional portrait, simple background, close framing, soft natural light, B&W. Link: MoMA `https://www.moma.org/collection/works/50989`
- Ansel Adams — *Clearing Winter Storm, Yosemite National Park* (c. 1937, printed later). Style: Landscape/modernist. Marks: dramatic mountains/clouds, strong contrast, sharp detail, deep space, B&W. Link: AIC `https://www.artic.edu/artworks/121723/clearing-winter-storm-yosemite-national-park`
- Man Ray — *Le Violon d'Ingres* (1924). Style: Surreal/studio. Marks: posed figure, playful transformation, smooth tones, careful lighting, B&W. Link: Getty `https://www.getty.edu/art/collection/object/104E4A`
- Robert Capa — *D-Day, Omaha Beach* (1944). Style: War reportage. Marks: intense action, motion blur/grain, on-the-spot framing, B&W, urgent mood. Link: Magnum `https://www.magnumphotos.com/newsroom/war/robert-capa-d-day/`
- Cindy Sherman — *Untitled Film Still #21* (1978). Style: Staged cinematic portrait. Marks: actress-like pose, storytelling vibe, controlled framing, B&W, classic film reference. Link: The Met `https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/266784`

- Alfred Stieglitz — *The Steerage* (1907). Style: Early modernist/documentary. Marks: strong geometry (lines/decks), layered space, everyday people, B&W. Link: The Met `https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/267836`

- Julia Margaret Cameron — *Sir John Herschel* (1867). Style: Pictorialist portrait. Marks: soft focus, gentle light, artistic pose, shallow DoF, B&W (albumen). Link: The Met `https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/282064`

- László Moholy-Nagy — *Photogram* (1926). Style: Bauhaus/experimental. Marks: camera-less image, shapes/textures on paper, high contrast, abstract design, B&W. Link: The Met `https://www.metmuseum.org/de/art/collection/search/265197`

- Gordon Parks — *American Gothic, Washington, D.C.* (1942). Style: Documentary portrait/social message. Marks: staged symbolism, centered figure, B&W, clear message. Link: Gordon Parks Foundation `https://www.gordonparksfoundation.org/publications/gordon-parks/american-gothic-gordon-parks-and-ella-watson`

- Imogen Cunningham — *Magnolia Blossom* (1925). Style: Modernist close-up. Marks: tight framing, smooth light, simple shapes, elegant curves, B&W. Link: SFMOMA `https://www.moma.org/collection/works/44263`

- Edward Weston — *Pepper No. 30* (1930). Style: Modernist still life. Marks: single object, dramatic light, glossy texture, sculptural curves, B&W. Link: SFMOMA `https://www.moma.org/audio/playlist/172/2274`

- Yousuf Karsh — *Winston Churchill* (1941). Style: Classic studio portrait. Marks: powerful pose/expression, controlled lighting, formal clothing, centered, B&W. Link: The Met `https://www.metmuseum.org/de/art/collection/search/264827`

- Lewis Hine — *Power House Mechanic Working on Steam Pump* (c. 1920). Style: Industrial documentary. Marks: worker and machine, strong angles/lines, textures, B&W, social message. Link: Brooklyn Museum `https://www.brooklynmuseum.org/nl-NL/objects/112132`

- Diane Arbus — *Identical Twins, Roselle, New Jersey* (1967). Style: Portrait with uncanny mood. Marks: centered twins, flat flash, direct gaze, subtle unease, B&W. Link: MoMA `https://www.moma.org/collection/works/58927`

- Brassaï — *Paris Night View* (e.g., Street, Montparnasse, 1933). Style: Night/urban documentary. Marks: deep shadows/bright highlights, fog/wet streets, dramatic mood, B&W. Link: Museu Tàpies `https://museutapies.org/en/exposicio/brassai/`

- Harold Edgerton — *Milk Drop Coronet* (1936). Style: High-speed photography. Marks: split-second splash, bright light, clean background, scientific feel, B&W. Link: MIT Museum `https://mitmuseum.mit.edu/collections/object/HEE-NC-57001`

- William Eggleston — *Untitled (Memphis)* (c. 1970). Style: Color documentary/everyday. Marks: vivid color, ordinary subject, careful framing, natural light, relaxed mood. Link: The Met `https://www.metmuseum.org/de/art/collection/search/302301`

- Sebastião Salgado — *Serra Pelada (Gold Mine, Brazil)* (1986). Style: Documentary/epic scale. Marks: huge crowd patterns, strong contrast, labor story, B&W. Link: Städel Museum `https://sammlung.staedelmuseum.de/de/werk/goldmine-serra-pelad`
- Elliott Erwitt — *California Kiss* (1955). Style: Street/humorous, romantic. Marks: candid moment, playful mood, simple shapes, B&W, clear subject. Link: Koch Gallery `https://kochgallery.com/exhibitions/elliott-erwitt-2017/`

Tips for recreating these photography styles with a phone

- Street/doc: shoot candid moments; use burst mode; keep distance; look for strong shapes and reflections.
- Portrait/classic: place subject by a window; use a plain background; center or off-center per mood; convert to B&W.
- Modernist close-up: find a single object; use side light; get very close; simplify the frame.
- Night/urban: shoot near windows or lamps; let shadows be dark; look for wet floors or shiny surfaces.
- High-speed: capture water splashes with bright light; use "Live Photo" or burst; pick the sharpest frame.
- Color documentary: find everyday scenes with bold colors; avoid heavy filters; let color lead the eye.